

One Choice Changes Everything

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Redefine Success and Discover the Work
That Makes You Feel Fully Alive

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The Unexpected Gifts Hidden in Your Struggles

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges so they become pathways for growth.

What Do the Leaning Tower of Pisa, Improvised Jazz, and Japanese Pottery Have in Common?

The Leaning Tower of Pisa was created by accident. A mistake made during its construction in 1173 caused the tower to tilt. In fact, the defective structural design had to be stabilized from a 5.5-degree tilt to a 3.97-degree tilt in the 1990s for safety reasons. Yet this unintentional defect has become one of its most celebrated features, drawing visitors from around the world. The defect created the beauty.

When musicians play improvised jazz, by definition, they do not follow the notes on the score. We delight in the new melodies formed by the deviation from the planned composition.

Imagine a shattered teacup, not discarded, but painstakingly pieced back together, the cracks filled with shimmering gold. This is *kintsugi*, a practice in Japanese pottery that sees beauty in imperfections. Instead of hiding the flaws, they are accentuated, creating a unique and beautiful piece of art.

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The Leaning Tower of Pisa, improvised jazz, and the Japanese art of *kintsugi* highlight how there is beauty in the unexpected, the irregular, the interruption of the pattern. You are no different. Your specific challenges are a high-definition image of your authenticity. No one else has experienced your difficulties with the level of detail and clarity that you have. Your challenges contain seeds of brilliance that you can use to create distinctive work.

The challenging experiences that leave you feeling shattered are not meant to be hidden. Just as the *kintsugi* artisan carefully restores each crack, you too can pick up the fragments of your past and begin the process of golden repair.

Just as a jazz musician is valued for their unique melodies, you too will find success by tackling issues connected to your personal struggles. The first step is to recognize that you are not your work.



Figure 2: The practice of kintsugi accentuates flaws by filling them with gold.
View and download this photo in full color at:
ChooseYourWorkBook.com/kintsugi

You Are Not Your Work

The most common reaction that people have when they think back to emotionally challenging experiences is, “Oh, I just wasn’t good enough.”

That’s very different from writing an article and wondering, “Is this a high-quality article?” This is a great question to ask because it will help you identify the criteria for high-quality work. By knowing these criteria, you will write a better article.

Observe the difference between “Is this a high-quality article?” and “Am I a good writer?” When you ask the latter question, you might hesitate and lower your self-worth. This leads to a feeling of despair. Instead of facing challenges and giving them your best shot, you get swept up in a mixture of overthinking and insecurity.

So how do we separate the two? Challenge the quality of your work, but never challenge your self-worth. At your core, you are whole. Nothing can diminish your inherent value.

You can further improve the quality of your work by changing “Is this a high-quality article?” to “What could make this article better?” This more specific approach avoids the heightened emotion connected to the vague “This is great” versus “This is terrible.” Your most perceptive insights emerge when you sit behind the article and contemplate both its strengths and weaknesses. Notice how this has everything to do with the article and nothing to do with you.

In the same way that you separate the quality of your work from the quality of yourself, it is equally important to distinguish between what happened in the past and who you are today. You are not your work. You are not your profession. You are not the situations you have encountered. You are something far greater.

In light of this separation, let’s now examine what happens if you fail to confront your past challenges.

The Problem with Ignoring a Challenging Experience

When I was working in the corporate world, I was emotionally disconnected from my work. My initial discomfort wasn't a sharp pain that was strong enough to compel change. Instead, it was more like a dull, recurring ache, the kind that lingers in the background and slowly wears you down. A persistent gray fog, absent of both joy and sadness, settled over my daily lukewarm mediocrity.

Some people suffer their entire lives with this familiar discomfort to the point that they stop noticing it. I eventually realized that when I numbed myself to one feeling, I actually numbed myself to all feelings. By failing to engage with my emotions, I was trapped in a maze of indecision, constantly second-guessing my choices and desires.

When you ignore your feelings, you are more likely to get stuck in unsatisfying work. The only thing worse than doing unsatisfying work is pretending that it's not a problem.

When you notice pain, feel the pain. When you notice joy, feel the joy.

Think back to a time in your past that was both emotionally intense and difficult to navigate. Pause to recall the specific sensations that you remember experiencing. Only by fully feeling the moment can you comprehend its larger significance.

Here is a series of comparisons by psychologist Steven C. Hayes to help you feel an experience more fully. For each comparison, pause long enough to connect it to a challenging experience.

Hold your experience like a delicate flower in your hand.

Embrace your experience like a crying child.

Sit with your experience like you would sit with a person with a serious illness.

Look at your experience like you would look at an incredible painting.

Walk with your experience like you'd walk while carrying a sobbing infant.

THE UNEXPECTED GIFTS HIDDEN IN YOUR STRUGGLES

Honor your experience like you'd honor a friend by listening carefully even if it was hard.

Inhale your experience the way you would take a deep breath.

Abandon the fight like a soldier putting down the weapon and walking home.

Take in your experience like a glass of pure cold water.

Carry your experience like a picture in your wallet.

In business, I've faced several setbacks. These comparisons have been invaluable in helping me to peacefully reconnect with a challenging experience, reframe it, and gain clarity. They have helped me realize that compassion is not just important for the sake of being kind to others. We are all grappling with our own internal struggles. By recognizing that most people are doing the best they can with what they have, compassion helps you to see more clearly.

Now that you have felt your challenging experience more fully, the next step is to let it go.

The Rock Concert

We're now going to transform your challenging experience into something new by doing an activity together.

Take a moment to revisit the experience and concentrate on a specific feeling it evokes. It could be anxiety — the tension or unease from a perceived threat. Maybe it's sadness — a heaviness or sorrow weighing on your mind. You might feel anger — a sense of resentment or irritation toward a situation or a certain person. Perhaps it's guilt — the feeling of responsibility for something that went wrong. Or maybe it's disappointment — the letdown when expectations are not met. Whichever emotion you notice, allow yourself to feel it fully for ten seconds.

Imagine you're standing in front of the stage at a rock concert, close enough to touch the performers. You don't just hear the music; you feel it reverberating through every bone in your body. The pounding bass

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echoes in your chest as the scent of smoke and sweat mingles in the air around you. Strobe lights flash intensely, painting the crowd in rapid, fleeting bursts of color.

This rock concert is a metaphor for your challenging experience — intense, overwhelming, and transformative. Don't engage with any words or thoughts. Just surrender to the raw sensation of the moment, letting it wash over you and carry you away on a tide of pure emotion.

Now imagine you're in a helicopter above the concert. With binoculars, you zoom in and see yourself immersed deeply in the rock concert, immersed in that painful experience. But when you take away the binoculars, you see everyone else at the concert. You can see the band, the lights, and thousands of people. You become a witness to the experience. Instead of being swept up by the emotion, you sit back in your seat and relax behind it, looking at the scene from a distance.

You stay with it. You don't comment. You simply observe it. You see it in its entirety, and then... you let it go. The helicopter departs from the scene. You look back toward the concert as it gets smaller and smaller and then disappears.

You are no longer there. The concert is now in the past. You are here in the present. It's a prior experience. It's not you. And as you let it go:

- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...

And you notice that you now feel a little bit lighter.

Look at the fragments of your experience. Were they broken, chipped, shattered? Take a breath. Imagine you're a *kintsugi* master, picking up the

pieces of this experience. As you allow gold to flow through the cracks, what was once pain is now transformed into beauty.

The experience is still part of you, but it no longer defines you. It transforms into something beautiful and strong that will guide you in the next stage of your journey. The transformation not only enriches your life, but by letting go of the past, you are able to make space for the future. With a lighter load, you are much better positioned to discover the work that you are meant to do.

Who Am I Now?

Too often we criticize our prior actions — even those from several years ago — to the point that we let them distort our present experience. Yet the cells in our bodies are replaced daily. In about ninety days, most of your roughly 30 trillion cells will transform into new ones. You are not only a more mature and experienced person with evolved thinking patterns; you are also a biologically different person from who you were several years ago.

If you were exactly the same person you were many years ago, you might be angry with yourself because you may repeat the same behavior. But you are a different person now. Even if you wanted to, replicating the past would be almost impossible. Yes, breathe a huge sigh of relief because the past is over and done with. You will still face challenges, and even if elements of the past repeat, knowing the future will differ from the past should bring you some joy. As your capacity to respond grows, you will have new, richer, and more interesting experiences than ever before.

After even a mildly intense experience, it can be interesting to ponder: Who am I now? How have I evolved? The answer: it's a mystery. You never quite know exactly who you are. All that you can be sure of is that you have grown. Maturity is about accepting the flux of life and recognizing that failure is baked into the process of growth.

How Your Challenges Help You Grow

Rabbi Harold Kushner reflected on the death of his son, who tragically passed away from a rare genetic disease at just fourteen years old. He said:

I'm a more sensitive person, a more effective pastor, a more sympathetic counselor because of Aaron's life and death than I would've been without it. And I would give up all those gains in a second if I could have my son back. If I could choose, I would forego all of the spiritual growth and depth, which has come my way because of our experience. But I cannot choose.

He not only accepted what happened, but he learned from it, grew from it, and moved forward. That's what we want to do now. We must take this difficult experience and move beyond acceptance. We must use it as a springboard to grow.

Viktor Frankl, an Austrian psychiatrist, personifies such growth. While trapped in the atrocities of a concentration camp, he articulated a profound truth with exceptional clarity:

We who lived in concentration camps can remember the men who walked through the huts comforting others, giving away their last piece of bread. They may have been few in number, but they offer sufficient proof that everything can be taken from a person but one thing: the last of the human freedoms — to choose one's attitude in any given set of circumstances, to choose one's own way.

To help survive these atrocious conditions, Frankl wrote notes about his work and hid them in his coat. He was dedicated to his craft for his entire lifetime. He knew what he stood for. For Frankl, psychiatry wasn't merely a profession. It was a calling. He knew that he was sent to do this work. So he did it, and he did it exceptionally well. Indeed, after being freed from the concentration camp, Frankl wrote his groundbreaking book *Man's Search for Meaning* in just nine days.

Sixty-nine years after Viktor Frankl wrote his book, Anthony Ray Hinton was released from prison in another part of the world. After

being framed by the police, Hinton was wrongfully imprisoned for a full thirty years, spending almost his entire time on death row. His Alabama prison cell was infested with rats and cockroaches. He was given scarcely enough food to survive. He spent barely fifteen minutes a day out of his cell. He heard the shrieks of other cellmates being executed in the electric chair. Then the odor of death filled the air, leaving a grim reminder of the execution that occurred just meters away.

How would you respond to these living conditions? While most would lose their composure, Hinton responded with a level of character that we can only hope to emulate, an inimitable ability to transcend the horrific conditions he endured and the gross injustice so mercilessly inflicted upon him. Recounting his experiences, this great man echoed the wisdom of Viktor Frankl, stating:

Despair was a choice. Hatred was a choice. Anger was a choice. I still had choices and that knowledge rocked me... I could choose to give up or to hang on. Hope was a choice. Faith was a choice. And more than anything, love was a choice.

While falsely imprisoned, Hinton established a book club for fellow inmates. After his release, instead of retreating into a private life, Hinton did the opposite. He devoted himself to public speaking, offering hope to those confronted by injustice. His quiet strength and powerful message resonated globally as he harnessed the transformative power of suffering to uplift the lives of others. Hinton's lost years behind bars fueled his public speaking with an intense energy that deeply impacted the lives of those who heard him speak.

Kushner, Frankl, and Hinton each accomplished something very rare. They mastered the art of emotional judo. Judo is the art of using your opponent's weight to redirect their force instead of confronting it head-on. Similarly, emotional judo harnesses negative emotions so that, instead of letting them weaken you, their weight elevates you to a higher level of consciousness. These men transcended their situations by choosing hope over despair, offering us a profound example of how to live.

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These experiences highlight that while there will always be challenges, the inescapable question is: Are you willing to use the force of these difficulties to create a transformation? These experiences are valuable because they give you depth, mold your character, and improve the quality of your thinking. As Camus put it, “In the depths of winter, I finally learned that within me there lay an invincible summer.”

These men also teach us how struggles can become the driving force behind work that is personally fulfilling and valuable to others. Just as Frankl further excelled in psychology and Hinton devoted himself to advocating for justice, you too can establish a new path illuminated by your challenging experiences.

Hopefully, you haven’t endured a fraction of the atrocities faced by Kushner, Frankl, or Hinton. However, if you hadn’t struggled at all, you wouldn’t appreciate the contrast between your past and present. More importantly, you can use these past struggles as seeds to cultivate something beautiful. The pain loses its sting when you absorb its lesson.

This is just the first stage of your journey. Your past challenges are here to help you navigate the next stage.

As the Zen proverb states, *Who knows what is good or bad luck?* It is easy to fall into the trap of believing that getting what you want will create the best experience for you. But more often, it is in the thick of challenging experiences that you uncover hidden gems. It is in these experiences that you break barriers, change perceptions, and create memories that leave an indelible mark on your life.

How to Channel Your Emotions to Build Something Remarkable

When John Wilson was twelve years old, his chemistry class participated in a routine experiment involving boiling water. Unfortunately, a lab assistant had mislabeled a bottle, so instead of boiling water, John boiled a much more reactive substance. The substance caused the container to

explode, shattering many glass bottles. Tragically, John Wilson left that science experiment completely blind.

Most people would be devastated, sink into depression, and lose hope. But John just got on with it. He quickly learned to read Braille, became an accomplished rower, swimmer, and actor, and studied law at Oxford University.

At age twenty-seven, he found himself in Africa. He noticed that blindness was far more prevalent there than in the Western world due to a lack of medical resources. He reflected on how his blindness resulted from an accident and grew angry that millions of others were blind simply due to insufficient resources. Something had to be done, so John established several organizations that helped prevent blindness in tens of millions of people.

If Sir John Wilson could turn his deeply unfortunate experience into a project that helped millions of people, what might be buried in your challenging experience, waiting to be uncovered? Observe the mixture of anger, frustration, and compassion that John felt and how he channeled that energy into something useful. Now, tap into the emotions that your challenges elicit. Feel the emotion deeply. Just as the *kintsugi* artist fills the cracks with gold, use the energy that comes from your challenges to create something that matters to you. Choose the work that fills the cracks with gold.

The Value of Writing About Challenges

When you write about your challenges, you release ideas that were taxing your mind. You expel negative emotions from your body. What once burdened your mind and strained your body now exists in its own place, on its own sheet of paper, separate from you. Now that you are no longer gripped by this narrow emotional focus, you can broaden your gaze and consider related thoughts. This is how you develop perspective.

The more you write, the more your writing reveals to you that you are not your thoughts. You are not your experiences. Your thoughts and

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experiences are separate from you because you are something far greater. You grow to discover that emotions stemming from difficult experiences have a perverse allure, leading you to replay them over and over in your head. But when you write about the experience and let it go, you uncover its hidden value as you progress to the next stage of your growth.

The Hidden Gift

Reflecting on the challenging experience visualized in this chapter:

1. What is the strongest emotion that surfaces when I think about my challenging experience? (e.g., fear, gratitude, relief, frustration)
2. As I sit with this emotion, what emerges as truly important? What have I learned about myself from this experience, and how have I grown from it?
3. Based on what I have learned, what is a project that I would love to pursue?

Duration

Two minutes per question

Feel free to extend this reflection if you're finding it valuable. Writing about challenges can be emotional, so be gentle with yourself. Through this reflection, you're beginning the process of transforming your challenges into sources of strength and insight.

Like the *kintsugi* master carefully mending cracks with gold, you're finding beauty and clarity in your struggles. Let this new perspective guide your choice of work. Perhaps a past experience revealed a hidden strength or highlighted a problem you're now driven to solve. Connect the dots between past and present to envision a project that feels less like a job and more like a calling.

Since this activity is more emotional than others, many find that writing by hand is the best way to complete it.

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How to Think Independently in a World Obsessed with Conformity

*Why does conforming to the herd
hamper your personal growth?*

The Tyranny of Human Thinking

About 3,000 years ago in China, the board game Go was created, and today it's one of the most complex games in existence. Two players take turns placing black and white stones on a grid, aiming to capture the most territory by surrounding their opponent's stones.

Early Go computer programs aimed to make the best moves by storing vast amounts of prior games and expert playing strategies. But when developers created AlphaGo in 2014, they used artificial intelligence to take a different approach. While earlier programs relied heavily on strategies derived by humans, AlphaGo stored only the game's basic rules and improved by repeatedly playing against itself. Sounds interesting, but how good is AlphaGo?

In March 2016, AlphaGo played Lee Sedol, one of the world's best Go players at the time. During the second match, on move thirty-seven, commentators of the game felt there were only two plausible moves — one being offensive and the other defensive. But AlphaGo instead played a

stunning third move. One commentator said, “Not a single human player would choose that move.” It seemed there was a glitch in the computer program. But AlphaGo won that game, and it turned out that move thirty-seven was not a glitch. It was a move so brilliant that it surpassed the present understanding of all Go players.

AlphaGo played this move precisely because it was not trained by humans. It became so good from playing itself, without human intervention, without being told the “proper way to play.” By merely observing patterns, it devised a strategy that was never contemplated during the game’s entire 3,000-year history. AlphaGo ended up defeating one of the world’s best players, not by knowing more human strategies, but by being unconstrained by them. In other words, AlphaGo won because it knew less than its human opponent and was therefore able to see more.

AlphaGo teaches us that not all human advice is good advice. This chapter is about realizing that you will receive a lot of bad advice in your lifetime. You will be told, “This is how it’s done.” People will say, “I expect you to do this.” Sometimes the advice given is helpful. Other times, there’s a lot of flashiness but not much depth, which means it is well-packaged advice. It sounds good, but if you interrogate this advice, if you break it down, it turns out to be a terrible idea.

Your job is to develop a compass to distinguish between what makes sense and moves you forward from what is nonsense and drags you backward. This is not something you can delegate. You can’t ask someone to think for you. If you seek only to please others, you will end up making many bad decisions. Where does this desire to please others come from?

The Adapted Self Versus the True Self

Earlier, we examined the interplay between the inner journey and the outer journey. Now, let’s examine how these journeys create your sense of identity. Specifically, we’ll explore the difference between what I call your adapted self — the part of you molded by external expectations — and your true self, the core of who you really are.

People ask, “What sort of phone do you have?”, “Do you own your home?”, “What car do you drive?”, “What’s your job title?” and then judge you based on your answers to these useless questions. As a result, you develop an adapted self, which trains you to fit in with others.

Your adapted self chases outer journeys to increase status. Your true self pursues inner journeys for personal growth.

Your adapted self conforms to cultural norms. Your true self honors your innermost aspirations.

Your adapted self crafts just the right post for social media. Your true self connects with close friends in the real world.

Your adapted self dictates what you *should* do. Your true self gently encourages you to imagine what you *could* do.

Your adapted self domesticates you to obtain external validation. Your true self seeks inner well-being.

To test whether an action originates from your true self rather than your adapted self, ask, “If I were not paid to do this, and I had to do it anonymously, would I pour my heart into it?”

You act from your true self when you are inspired to do something purely because it feels deeply right. In contrast, you act from your adapted self when your actions are aimed at enhancing your status, impressing others, or seeking their approval.

There’s value in being respectful and working harmoniously with others, so an adapted self can be a helpful persona. In prehistoric times, social cohesion was crucial for protecting against predators, finding food, and caring for the young. The problems arise when we let our adapted self suffocate our true self.

I know a man who became a dentist because his mother constantly encouraged him to do so. She meant well, wanting him to have a “good job” with financial stability. His adapted self quietly deferred to her request, but he ended up earning a fraction of what he expected, hating his work, and feeling trapped in a deeply unfulfilling career.

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The most well-meaning advice can still cause the greatest harm.

I witnessed this situation in my own family. My parents, who migrated to Australia from humble beginnings, emphasized the importance of security and stability. They encouraged me to pursue a traditional career path like engineering or medicine, one that offered financial security and social recognition. While I understood their perspective, I also recognized that I had to live my own life, not merely copy their lives. There are some decisions that you, and you alone, must make for yourself. I did my best to be respectful. Equally, I felt that if my true self's aspirations conflicted with their expectations, it was my responsibility to prioritize the former over the latter.

Many athletes at the Olympics also illustrate the strength of the adapted self. The medal system, with gold, silver, and bronze, creates a very strange effect. Specifically, if someone wins a bronze medal, they're usually happier than when they win a silver medal, which seems illogical because silver is the higher achievement. Why does this happen?

The reason is that when someone wins a bronze medal, their adapted self thinks, "Well, at least I have a medal." But when someone wins a silver medal, the adapted self says, "If only I had beaten this one person, I would've won a gold medal."

The creation of a social construct — gold, silver, and bronze — causes many athletes to forget the joy of competing. Similarly, many parents become so consumed by developmental milestones that they fail to enjoy time with their kids. Students are often so busy comparing their grades with each other that they don't have space to find joy in the actual subject.

The root of the problem seems to be that we do not question social constructs like medals and instead imitate others without even noticing it. This unconscious imitation is facilitated by mirror neurons in our brains, which fire when we observe someone else performing an action. This sparks mimetic desire — the desire to have certain things simply because other people have them.

It's a frightening idea to consider how many of your thoughts and desires may not actually be your own. There's a good chance that many of your thoughts are merely duplicates of other people's thoughts. If that's true, then what does that say about your life? It means that a great deal of your life is not really your own. It's a life that has been largely copied from other people.

But there is a way to get back on track.

How to Connect with Your True Self

Many years ago, I woke up at 4 a.m. and a realization hit me all at once. I got out of bed and wrote this down —

I'm a writer but I'm not really that.

I'm a director of a business but I'm not really that.

I'm a runner but I'm not really that.

I'm a juggler but I'm not really that.

I'm a spirit. I'm the fire. The light. The energy. The music. The magic.

I don't need to dress myself in any of the disguises above.

So who are you really?

You are not your profession. People change their professions all the time. You are not your body. Your body changes with exercise and age. You are not your mind. Your thoughts and emotions come and go. You are not your adapted self that has learned all the rules. At your essence, you are your true self, the pure energy who is a witness to it all.

Think of your mind as a flowing river of thoughts and emotions. These thoughts and emotions are constantly changing, just like the water in the river. However, you are not the river itself. Instead, you are the observer standing on the riverbank, watching the water flow by. This observer, this awareness, is your true self.

At your core, you are the constant, unchanging presence that observes all these experiences. You are the witness to all the thoughts and emotions

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that pass through your mind. Recognizing this can help you connect with your true self — the pure energy that is always there, beyond the fluctuations of the mind.

What then stops you from staying in touch with your true self?

Does Your Lifestyle Interfere with Your Life?

Your true self cannot operate when your life is driven by disguises. Social media encourages you to present a manicured fraction of who you are. What brand is your car? Your watch? Your clothes? The more effort you put into these choices, the more you live through your disguises.

It's not just social media. People buy expensive cars, designer clothes, and shiny gadgets, hoping to impress others. But most people are too absorbed in their own vanities and insecurities to notice. Even if they do notice, does it really matter? Trying to satisfy someone else's odd preferences seems like a poor use of your precious energy.

There's no real need to own trendy clothes or an expensive car. It's just a perceived need born from a bizarre story that says your life becomes more significant when decorated with overpriced objects. But when you strip away the story, the charade collapses. You realize that many people resort to pretentiousness because if their significance relied on substance, they would feel insignificant. The desire for extravagance is simply a failed attempt to satisfy an inner sense of emptiness. No matter how extravagant you get, the emptiness persists.

With an undeveloped true self and without a compass to guide you, the safest alternative is to comply with the dominant social narrative. It feels safe. But compliance is not free. The cost of following someone else's story is the inability to create your own story. The cost of settling for a socially approved job is often the work that you love. Are you willing to pay that cost? Are you willing to allow your adapted self to entangle you in a lifestyle that prevents your true self from creating a fulfilling life?

It's easy to get sucked in by the adapted self. It's easy to want to feel special. It's easy to admire certain people and crave their praise. It's easy to do what is expected until one day you realize that you have abandoned your true self. It's easy until it's not.

Over the years, I've worked on loosening the grip of my adapted self. I drive a Toyota Corolla, not because I can't afford a more expensive car, but because several mechanics told me it's the most reliable car. I have no interest in how other people perceive my choices. In fact, if someone disapproves, I see it as a helpful filter because they're unlikely to value who I truly am. I avoid spending energy seeking validation so I can invest it in what really matters.

So what really matters to you? If you are enchanted by the inner machinery of a watch, buy beautiful watches. If your favorite sound is the growl of an engine, buy a fast car. If, at your core, you are delighted by the texture and soft touch of certain fabrics, buy expensive clothes. But before you make these decisions, ask yourself, "Do these things genuinely bring joy to my heart? Or am I chasing insipid objects to impress others at the expense of pursuing the things that bring lasting satisfaction?"

By prioritizing external validation over internal satisfaction, the adapted self commits the great crime of disconnecting you from your true feelings. How many people are so wedded to the idea of a reliable salary that they have never contemplated work that inspires them? How many lawyers are so focused on winning cases that they have never paused to consider whether they find joy in supporting their clients? How many entrepreneurs are so obsessed with scaling their business that they lose sight of building something innovative that their clients love?

Tame your adapted self so that you never let an ideology blunt your senses. Examine how you feel when you do your work and let that feeling be your guiding light.

Among the misguided ideologies that distract the adapted self, the obsession with money ranks near the top. In his book *Never Enough*, investor and entrepreneur Andrew Wilkinson observes how whenever

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he heard someone get asked, “What’s your number? What’s the amount in your bank account you’d need to feel as though you had enough?” the answer was always the same. It was always double what the person currently had in their bank account. He found that the person with \$500,000 felt they would have peace of mind with \$1 million. Someone with \$1 million in savings believed they just needed \$2 million, and so on.

Wilkinson’s observation reveals an ugly truth about the adapted self: it is never satisfied. If your adapted self allows your net worth to influence your self-worth, it will ruin your life. Every unit of energy spent chasing money comes at the expense of a unit of energy that could be invested in pursuing your true aspirations. The cycle of accumulation blinds you from what really matters.

Your true self knows what matters. Your only challenge is to listen.

How to Unmask Your Adapted Self and Listen to Your True Self

Recognize your adapted self intervening when you hear variations of the phrase, “Once I hit my number, or once XYZ happens, I will stop what I’m doing and start living from my true self.” The painful reality is that by the time that day arrives, you will have changed so much that you will no longer identify with the more youthful and vibrant version of yourself. Those bold visions you once had will be lost forever.

Additionally, the principle of hedonic adaptation holds that even if you reach “your number” or achieve your goal, the satisfaction it brings will be short-lived. The temporary high will fade and you will quickly adapt to the new reality. In other words, you will feel almost identical to how you felt before you set the goal! The only real impact will be that you disconnected from your true self, chasing fleeting rewards at the expense of the life that you desire most.

When you hear your adapted self demanding something, do not mute the voice. It will only come back blaring stronger next time. Instead, pause and listen to the message. Consider why your adapted self is making the

request. Let your true self have a dialogue with your adapted self. When you feel pulled toward a choice driven by external validation — the flashy car, the designer outfit, the latest distraction, or the approval of a group — observe your adapted self clamoring for attention. Instead of succumbing, bring awareness to that impulse and examine it impartially. Where is it coming from? Ask yourself, “Why do I feel drawn to this? Does it align with my true self, or is it stemming from an insecurity or a need for external validation?”

By exploring the motivations behind your adapted self’s cravings, you create space for your true self to emerge and guide your actions. This internal dialogue helps you distinguish between the shallow desires of your adapted self and the deeper aspirations of your true self. With practice, you’ll become more attuned to the distinct voices within and better equipped to make choices that honor your true self.

This unmasking process can feel profoundly uncomfortable as you confront raw truths. A well-crafted façade feels safer because it shields against the sting of rejection from family and the expectations of the world. It’s like being one of those people who has beautiful furniture, but instead of touching the gorgeous fabric, the plastic is left on to ensure the furniture remains clean.

Unmasking, then, is an act of courage, a deliberate step toward seeing who you really are. It’s only possible to travel to the depth of your potential when you are willing to expose your imperfections to the world.

When your adapted self stops overpowering your true self, you find peace and your priorities change. Intangibles such as serenity become far more valuable than trivial tangibles. When you are in touch with your true self, you value experiences over outcomes, not because you don’t like results — you love results, and indeed you achieve many varied and profound results. But from all these achievements, you discover that the best result is a compelling experience. Enriching experiences amplify your capacity to experience awe, and in doing so, these rich experiences

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

become intertwined with your identity. As your true self constructs a more nuanced narrative, you evolve to the next level.

At the end of the day, you need to make an important decision. Decide whether you want to feel happy at your core or whether you merely want to appear happy to others. Is your appearance more important than your actual experience? If fulfillment is the priority, begin by looking deeply at who you truly are. Examine your unmasked true self. Penetrate to the core of your being and ponder what really matters to you. More likely than not, you will discover the answer does not involve a new pair of expensive shoes or a shiny new car.

Freedom is the ability to direct your energy toward the things that matter to you.

Permission Is Not Required

To get in touch with your true self, stop asking for permission. Stop saying:

Before I get a job, I must have a degree.

Before I am respected, I must have a certain job title.

Before I can be successful, I must own a house.

Before I am talented, I must win a competition.

Before I matter, I must have a certain amount of money.

Before I look good, I must weigh a certain amount.

Before I am spiritual, I must join a certain religion.

Before I am happy, I must have a romantic relationship.

Whenever you ask for permission, you give someone veto power over your life. This needs to stop. Stop going through life looking for confirmation that you are not good enough unless you jump through a certain hoop. You'll always find someone claiming you're not good enough when you don't do things their way. That's exactly why the commentators incorrectly believed that there was a glitch in the AlphaGo computer program.

I've even seen, tragically, a teacher tell an impressionable student, "You are not good at math," and because the statement was taken personally, it became a self-fulfilling prophecy. Your self-worth is not based on what other people think of you or the way things have always been done.

In fact, your self-worth is non-negotiable because it's a reflection of your unalterable, true self. Don't let anyone entertain the notion that you do not have value to contribute to this world. If someone tries to put you down, simply respond, "Thank you for your feedback." There's no need to become angry or defensive. Simply recognize that their criticism often stems from their own insecurities and that their inner turmoil has nothing to do with you.

There has never been anyone like you in the past and there will never be anyone like you in the future. You are immeasurable and irreplaceable. The value that stems from your distinctiveness can never be dismissed, even when other people fail to grasp it. Once you comprehend your value, the opinions of others lose their sting. You need to get to the point where you can say to yourself:

If people are upset because I live my truth, if they are upset by the expression of my true self, so be it.

Otherwise, you will be paying the cost of pleasing others, which will stop you from expressing who you truly are. Playing it safe invariably means giving up the things that matter the most to you. Playing it safe is surrendering your precious time to a job that drains your energy, surrounded by people who bring you no joy, solving meaningless problems. Playing it safe is the most dangerous thing that you can do.

The people who criticize you for following your path usually struggle to find their own path. They haven't engaged with the challenging questions you're exploring, so they can't possibly understand your responses. Mature people don't care about your job title. They only want to know whether you dare to dream, whether you have the audacity to listen to your heart as your primary source of information.

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

To those who understand you, no words are needed. To those who do not, no words are possible.

Luciano Pavarotti, however, was able to find the words that expressed his relationship with his work. A reporter once asked the famous opera singer, “What do you do the night before a big opera? Do you socialize?”

Pavarotti replied, “No, I stay home and rest my voice.”

The reporter was full of praise. “Wow! You’re so disciplined!”

Pavarotti corrected, “No, it’s not discipline; it’s devotion.”

Pavarotti didn’t see resting his voice as a sacrifice because he understood the important distinction between discipline and devotion.

Discipline involves focusing your mind on tasks you must do as a matter of duty. Devotion, on the other hand, is acting on your heart’s desire to be completely dedicated to your chosen craft.

When you are in touch with your true self, your sense of comparison evaporates and you no longer require the approval of others to move forward. You simply choose your work. So to what degree should you listen to others?

The Value and Limits of Humility

We’ve been told to pay attention, take notes, and speak only when spoken to. Indeed, there is merit in humility. There is value in learning from others. Other people have experienced different things than you. They have acquired different knowledge than you. If you listen hard enough, there is always something that you can learn.

It is equally essential to listen with a sense of doubt because you have your own experiences. You have your own knowledge. Indeed, you know yourself far more intimately than anyone else. If you blindly submit to the will of another person, you insult the intrinsic value that only you can express. That’s why you need to develop your own compass.

All progress in this world has been achieved through the vehicle of doubt. Aristotle's ideas on motion were doubted and falsified by Galileo in 1638. Newton doubted that Galileo had provided the full picture and created Newton's laws of motion in 1687. Newtonian physics was thought to explain the universal laws of motion for more than 200 years. But in 1900, Max Planck doubted Newtonian physics and, in doing so, discovered quantum physics, proving that Newton's laws of motion do not apply at the quantum level. Then Einstein doubted that Max Planck had the full story and won the Nobel Prize by building on Planck's ideas.

Similarly, AlphaGo was successful because it was free from the assumptions of its human predecessors. Progress is made when someone comes along and says, "I get the feeling that I have work to do here. There's something missing here," and eventually, "You know what? I think that I can do better." Progress is made from the mixture of humility and doubt.

It is easy to accept things as they are, but the inventors' thirst for progress moved us all forward. They are no different from you. Stand up for what you know to be true, even when it's hard, even when it feels scary, even when it makes you slightly less popular with others. Live a life, as Maslow said, that is "independent of the good opinion of others."

Listen to everyone. Read widely. But most importantly, observe how you feel.

The meaning of life is no more important than the feeling of life.

Trust your deepest feelings and approach each scenario with both a sense of humility and a sense of doubt. The secret to success is not connected to your ability to follow instructions. Far more important is your ability to ask and respond to your own questions.

Let's activate your true self with the next activity.

The Hidden Voice

1. *What is one potential project my true self wants to express but is being delayed or dismissed by my adapted self?*
2. *Write a short paragraph about why this project aligns with your true self.*

Duration

Two minutes

This may be a challenging reflection as it requires deep honesty with yourself. It takes courage to question external expectations, but staying true to yourself is the foundation of a fulfilling life. Consider coming back to this question in a week to build on your thoughts.

Carry on past the timer if you're uncovering something important. This reflection is intentionally short because small, regular adjustments lead to profound results.

Write Your Reflections Here

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I have identified one project that my true self wants to express.

In the Next Chapter...

When you ask your own questions, you will often stumble on joy effortlessly. You know what else this can lead to? Extraordinary achievements. We'll explore this process next.

Praise for *Choose Your Work*

Choose Your Work is both deeply personal and profoundly universal. It is insightful, provocative, and quietly unsettling. It seamlessly blends research and real-world anecdotes with practical, step-by-step guidance to help you identify what matters most. This is a book for anyone who has ever sensed there must be more — more meaning, more joy, more alignment between who they are and the work they do.

Genia Janover | Award-Winning Former Principal | Bialik College | Former Fellow | Australian College of Educators

Dan Dobos says the scary, quiet thing out loud: how we spend our working lives is a choice. *Choose Your Work* is both a wake-up call and a practical roadmap for anyone ready to make that choice.

Ben Stickland | Co-Founder & CEO | Instamove

This is the kind of book I will go back to regularly. Some self-help books you read once. Others bring value over and over throughout your life. This is the latter.

Teshia Harding

Choose Your Work distills a lifetime of insights and wisdom into a practical guide to help you clarify what matters most.

Jonar Nader | Former IBM Executive | Author of *How to Lose Friends & Infuriate Your Boss*

Chapter Two alone helped me more than therapy has.

Kayla Giles

Choose Your Work is a timely and deeply needed guide for anyone who senses there must be more to work than simply earning a living. In a volatile world that pushes people toward conformity, this book offers a practical and thought-provoking path back to what truly matters.

Mark Bowles | Dean, Tasmanian School of Business and Economics | University of Tasmania

In my work as a psychotherapist, I see how easy it is to lose sight of who you truly are. *Choose Your Work* offers a thoughtful and compelling path back to yourself.

Kirk Fisher | Psychotherapist & Zen Teacher

Honest, raw, and real. *Choose Your Work* was exactly what I needed.

Christy Oshima

Unlike other career change manuals, this is a guide for those searching for fulfilling work that is both optimistic and encouraging.

Helen Praetz | Emeritus Professor and Former Pro Vice-Chancellor | RMIT University

If you know someone graduating college, buy them this book. If a friend just turned 30, buy them this book. Most people stumble into careers that 'kinda work' and there they remain stuck. Don't be like most people. Buy this book.

James Tuckerman | Founder | Anthill Magazine

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**Have you ever felt the unnerving sensation that,
despite appearing successful, something deep down isn't quite right?**

When you look back at your life, will you be satisfied?
Or will you have regrets?

The dark side of grit is chasing goals that don't matter,
while your deepest desires quietly fade away.

The way forward is to realize that the secret to a
fulfilling life is to choose your work.

**In this thought-provoking book, packed with inspiration,
practical strategies, and insightful stories, you will discover...**

What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?

•

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges to realize your potential

•

Strategies to choose your work while still paying the bills

•

Why being good at something may lead you down the
wrong path and how to find the right one

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Why focusing on comfort can ruin your life and
obscure the true metrics of success



**This book will help you discover your deepest truth, redefine what
success means to you, and begin a fulfilling new chapter in your journey.**

"Compelling and thought-provoking. It inspired immediate action in my life."

Beau Florenosos

"Inspirational, memorable and unlike any self-help book I've read before."

Jean Rose Dogillo

"Engaging, energising and deeply thought-provoking."

Liz Treat